

through satellite connectivity

- Nine hardpoints, or weapon stations—eight located on the wings and one on the centreline
- Can execute precision-guided ground bombing with GBU-12 Paveway II laser-guided bombs, GBU-38 Joint Direct Attack Munition (JDAM) kits
- Can be armed with air-to-air Sidewinder, surface-to-air Stinger missiles to target airborne objects; air-to-ground Hellfire missiles can target armour and other ground objects
- The US and its allies have extensively deployed MQ-9 series drones over Afghanistan, Iraq, Yemen and Libya

After some hard bargaining by the cost negotiation committee, India hopes to secure the drones for a better price than other buyers such as the UAE have paid

the navy had leased in November 2020 had covered over 14 million square miles of operating area—much of it over the LAC—in over 10,000 flight hours. That, and the various strike capabilities of the MQ-9Bs, must have forced a rethink.

Under the current deal, the MoD's Acceptance of Necessity is the beginning of the acquisition process. The FMS (foreign military sales) programme is multi-tiered and managed by the Defense Security Cooperation Agency for the US Department of Defense. Once India issues a Letter of Request (LoR) to Washington, officially expressing its intention to acquire the MQ-9Bs, the US will respond with a letter of offer and acceptance (LoA) after a nod from the US Congress.

Following this, the terms of procurement will be negotiated. An Indian technical compliance and evaluation committee will assess the exact requirements of the Indian military. The cost negotiation committee will come into the picture next, and will do the hard bargaining on behalf of the MoD, including comparing the price and terms offered to other countries. Once the price is finalised, the deal will be put up before the cabinet committee on security, chaired by the prime minister, for final approval. India and the US will sign a letter of acceptance then, before GA starts delivery.

"Military procurement is a lengthy process and has to pass through 11 stages, though efforts are on to lock the deal as early as possible," says an officer involved in the procurement. India will also negotiate for a higher element of technology transfer. It is looking at 20 per cent of the Make in India element, against the eight per cent offered by GA.

A top MoD official claims that the average estimated cost of an MQ-9B offered to India is 27 per cent lower than the price other countries pay and that there will be further hard bargaining. The final price may vome to $99 million (Rs 818 crore) per drone. By comparison, says the official, the UAE purchased it at $161 million (Rs 1,330 crore) apiece. And the MQ-9B India is looking to acquire has a better configuration, he adds. The UK purchased 16 MQ-9Bs cheaper, for $69 million (Rs 570 crore) each, but those were only 'green aircraft'—sans sensors and weapons. Features like sensors, weapons and payloads make up 60-70 per cent of the total cost, another MoD official explains, adding that even the US itself acquired five MQ-9Bs at $119 million (Rs 983 crore) each. GA did not respond to INDIA TODAY's queries on the pricing of the drones.

However, some argue that a lesser number of MQ-9Bs than the 31 ordered might have sufficed. A senior army commander claims that with better integration between the three services, the forces could have done with half the number. He argues against buying highly-priced machines for the three wings of the armed forces separately. "When we are talking about synergy in the forces, these machines should be under one organisation. With sharing of information, there is no need to buy so many," the officer says. He points out that an MQ-9B can cover all airbases and military installations of Pakistan while flying along the LoC, and can provide real-time information on all Chinese military assets in Tibet while deployed over the LAC. A section of the defence establishment insists that the focus should be on indigenous drones like the Tapas-BH-201, developed by the Bengaluru-based Aeronautical Development Establishment, which achieved an altitude of 28,000 feet and 18 hours of endurance in March 2022.

Currently, Indian forces are mostly dependent on foreign-made drones, like the Israel-made Heron and Searchers, and that too to gather intelligence. Under the Rs 5,000 crore Project Cheetah, the IAF is looking to upgrade its existing fleet of Heron drones for offensive missions. The drones are being fitted with laser-guided bombs and air-to-ground and air-launched anti-tank missiles. ■